The real world

A broker's mechanics, what a trade really costs, what the gain is taxed at — and a review of eleven weeks of decisions that looks at the decisions, not the results.

We grade decisions, not outcomes.

Education, not advice.

0:00 — HARVEST

What has your paper account cost you?

The Monday line

Round the room: the rule's state, the stop, the report's sentence, the watchlist's word. Five minutes a week — that is the whole routine.

The number on your page

Every ticket has a cost line. Nobody knows what it stands for. Tonight it gets a receipt: a broker's schedule, a conversion, a spread, a tax form.

Tonight

A broker's screen in the course's words · what the trade really costs (/costs) · Irish tax, three ways · explain my portfolio · the register check · demo day's homework.

Graham said what; Carver said when and how much; the tutor said how to check. The real world adds what it costs and what you keep. Neither changes the rules.

Seven things to read off the fee page

Who regulates it	A branch of a German bank (BaFin), serving Ireland under the EU passport, Dutch conduct rules. On the German and Dutch registers; not supervised by the Central Bank of Ireland. Find the firm on a register BEFORE the money moves.
The profile	Basic — no margin, no shorting, no derivatives — is the only one the course recognises: the Starter System's unleveraged variant. The others exist to lend you money.
The order	Market, limit, stop-loss, stop-limit; a day or until cancelled. The course's stop is a CLOSING-PRICE rule read on the close — not an order resting with the broker that fires on a wobble at 11am.
The currency	A euro account buys dollars: 0.25% each way automatically, or a manual conversion with a fixed fee plus the 0.25%. The dividend arrives in dollars.
The dividend	Withheld at 30% — 15% with a W-8BEN on file (the first statement shows which). The rest is income: 0:40.
The small print	Securities lending · €2.50 a year per foreign exchange · the compensation scheme (German: deposits €100,000, investments 90% to €20,000). Facts, not fears.
The statement	Raw data — buys, sells, distributions, conversions. The broker reports nothing to Revenue for you. Your record is your own: the ticket and the journal, for eleven weeks.

0:25 — WHAT THE TRADE REALLY COSTS

€10,000, a US share, three years, +30%

Commission and handling, buy €2.00 · sell €2.00 · conversion, buy €25.00 · sell €32.50 · the spread (0.1%) €10.00 · connectivity, 3 years €7.50

To open and close: €79.00. The course's model ($2 + 0.25% a ticket, both tickets): $61.50 — the paper account's cost line was a real cost.

The same money in a euro-listed ETF: €1 an order, no conversion, no stamp duty — and 0.2% a year taken inside the price: €69 over the holding, the cost you never see on a statement.

Tens of euro

The trade. Two orders, two conversions, a spread, a line of connectivity. Change the size to €2,000 and watch the fixed fees matter.

Tens a year

The holding. A fund's annual charge; the withholding on a dividend; a small cap's spread — week 2's surprise, ten times the large cap's.

Hundreds

The tax. The next slide. Trade costs are a rounding error beside it — which is why the course sized on costs and spent an evening on tax.

The same €3,000 gain, taxed three ways

Shares, outside — €536.30

Capital gains tax: 31% for disposals on or after 7 Oct 2026 (33% before). The first €1,270 of a year's gains exempt. A loss offsets gains on shares and carries forward. 31% of €1,730. — THE RATE IS A BILL

A fund or ETF, outside — €1,050

The exit tax: 38% in 2026, 35% from 1 Jan 2027 (41% to the end of 2025). No exemption; no relief for a loss; a deemed disposal every eight years. 35% of €3,000; €1,140 if sold this year. — THE 35% IS A BILL

Inside the new account — €0

The Individual Investment Account, from 1 July 2027 on a commencement order: €12,000 a year in; nothing inside; 1% a year on the average daily value above €50,000 — a charge on value, payable in a losing year too. — THE WHOLE ACCOUNT IS A BILL

Two things the Bill as published does not settle: whether a share listed only in the US qualifies, and how US withholding is treated inside. For the Act and Revenue's guidance — said out loud.

THE DATES, THE DIVIDENDS, THE RECORD

When it is paid, and what you keep

CGT, paid	By 15 December for disposals January–November; by 31 January for December's. The return — CG1, or Form 11 / Form 12 — by 31 October of the following year.
The exit tax, paid	Self-assessed on Form 11 / Form 12 for the year of a sale or an eighth anniversary. The broker's statement is raw data; nothing is filed for you.
Dividends	US: 15% withheld with a W-8BEN (30% without), then income at your marginal rate with USC and PRSI, credit for the 15%. Irish: 25% withholding tax, credited. A fund's distribution: the exit-tax rate.
Stamp duty	1% buying shares in an Irish company; 0.5% UK; none on US shares or Irish-domiciled ETFs. At purchase.
The record	Date, quantity, price, the conversion rate, the cost line, the reason — for every buy and sell. The ticket has carried all of these since week 8. A journal entry is a tax record with a reason attached.
The discipline	A Bill is not an Act. The page says 'as checked on 12 Nov 2026' and marks every line that depends on the Bill; before anyone acts on a figure it is re-checked against the Finance Act and Revenue's guidance. The habit, not the numbers.

1:00 — EXPLAIN MY PORTFOLIO

Did you follow your rules?

The audit — no AI

The rules applied to the rows. NOT FOLLOWED: a stop hit and the position still open more than a trading week later; a close with the stop not hit; a close later than the week's routine. FOLLOWED: the stop answered within the week; opened with the rule long. JOURNAL: word tests — no rule named, no stop. THE REPORT: the flags, counted.

A drawdown is not a breach

The rules do nothing about it (week 9). Over-budget and too-many-positions nights are the account's arithmetic — a share got wilder, or N changed — not a ticket you wrote. The audit says so.

Fewer shares is not a breach

The rule allows fewer, never more (week 8). The review does not judge size; it states it. And it does not read minds: a journal note says what the template asks for, nothing more.

The audit is free and always there. The reading is a second opinion in plain words — checked.

THE READING

A sheet with no P&L on it

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F1. The account runs 2 instruments by the course's rules: open only when the rule is LONG on the latest close; size by instrument risk; close at the stop; a journal entry on every ticket …

F3. Ticket #2: open 29 × KO on the 2026-10-20 close; the rule was LONG. Journal: «Bought because it seemed cheap and I liked the brand.»

F9. KO: opened 2026-10-20 (ticket F3), 29 shares at $94.08; closed on the 2026-11-02 close (ticket F4) with the stop NOT hit; the rule was LONG on that close.

WHAT THE AUDIT FOUND: A1 [breach] AAPL: the stop was hit on the 2026-10-28 close and the position is still open … A2 [breach] KO: closed with the stop not hit …
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It cannot praise what it cannot see

None of the toolkit's profit, loss, account-value or drawdown figures, and no price level beyond the entry, is on the sheet. What is: your own journal words, as you wrote them — quoted in fragments, result words not repeated. 'We grade decisions, not outcomes' — tonight the machine does it because the result is hidden from it.

Checked, like the tutor

A fact tag not on the sheet · a paragraph citing nothing · a number from nowhere · a tip · and — new — OUTCOME LANGUAGE: well done, profit, it went up, lucky, paid off. Any one of them and the reading is withheld; the page says why; the audit stands.

Your job

Open 'The sheet the AI reads' under the page. Click a fact tag; find the sentence. Three readings a day per account; the prompt's version is printed on every one.

THE EXERCISE, IN PAIRS

A deliberately rule-breaking book

AAPL	Opened 20 Oct with the rule long; the stop hit on the 28 Oct close; still open on 10 Nov — nine nightly reports have said so. NOT FOLLOWED: the rule said close.
KO	Opened 20 Oct («seemed cheap, liked the brand»); closed 2 Nov with the stop not hit («nervous about the market»), at a profit. NOT FOLLOWED: the stop is the closing rule; this was a second rule — 'how I feel tonight'. The profit is not on the sheet.
MSFT	Opened 20 Oct with the stop named in the entry; the stop hit on the 27 Oct close; the close ticket written one close later, within the week's routine — at a loss. FOLLOWED. The loss is not on the sheet either.
The question	What would a reading that said 'well done on KO' be? — Withheld, and the page says why. What would the audit say if the stop on AAPL had hit yesterday? — A note: due, within the week's routine.

A stop being hit is a process event, not a bad outcome. Closing on it is the rule, followed.

The platform itself

The four checks

1 · The firm on a register (the Central Bank's, or its home regulator's under the passport). 2 · The NUMBER from the register — a clone copies the name, address and licence and changes only the bank account. 3 · A published fee page. 4 · The exit: how, in what currency, in how many days.

The red flags

Unregistered or 'offshore-regulated' · guaranteed or monthly returns · a deadline, a bonus for depositing today · an ad or a celebrity that found you · remote-access software · a fee to withdraw · a dashboard that only goes up · a second firm to 'recover your losses' · crypto or forex 'platforms' with a manager.

What you lose

With an unauthorised firm: the Investor Compensation Scheme (90% to €20,000) and the Ombudsman — both exist only for authorised firms. Report: (01) 224 5800, centralbank.ie/financialscams. Keep the messages and the dates.

A confident wrong answer and a confident wrong platform sell the same way — fluency. The defence is the same: find the register entry, find the number, check it yourself.

kit/scam-spotting-notes.md, part 2 — the register at registers.centralbank.ie; the Bank's warnings most weeks

1:25 — HOMEWORK + CLOSE

Price your book; read your review; write the rule

1 · Price your own book

Run /costs with your largest paper trade's size and its gain or loss to date. Write the three tax figures in the journal, with the date you checked them and 'Bill, not law' where it applies.

2 · Ask for a reading

Of your own account. Check two fact tags against the sheet. If a reading carried a flag, bring it. 3 · The register check, written into the journal as a rule: before any money moves, the firm on a register, the number from the register.

4 · Demo day

Choose the one decision from your journal you will present next week — before and after — judged on process, not on what the price did. Bring the entry.

Close with the sentence: we grade decisions, not outcomes.

GO DEEPER — FREE, FOREVER, OPTIONAL

Where tonight's two pages come from

The audit is a pure function over your rows; the reading is week 6's discipline with one more check; the worksheet is a table of dated rules and some arithmetic:

AUDIT src/lib/review.ts — auditProcess: the rules applied to tickets, positions and the nightly reports; the sheet the model reads (process facts only); describeAudit

READING src/review.ts — the prompt (versioned: r2), the per-student and class budgets counted insert-first in `reviews` (migration 0012), the receipts in fetch_log

CHECKS src/lib/explain.ts (numbers, the advice families) + src/lib/review.ts (OUTCOME_PATTERNS, checkReading) — a reading that fails is withheld; the audit stands

WORKSHEET src/lib/costs.ts — TAX_RULES (every rate with its date and basis), BROKER, the three regimes; /costs and /api/costs; no database, no model

PAGES /tickets/<code>/review · /api/explain-my-portfolio/<code> (the audit; ?ai=1 for a reading) · /costs · /api/costs — and the two kit pages, now in the tutor's notes too